5-Ingredient Dinners: Short Grocery List, Real Dinner | Trillion Man Outreach

Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

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By the Trillion Man Outreach kitchen crew Updated October 8, 2026

Fewer ingredients means a shorter list, less chopping and less money spent on things that rot in the crisper. These dinners use five main ingredients, not counting oil, salt and pepper. Here are seven to try and the formula to invent your own.

The five-ingredient formula

Pick one starch, one protein, one vegetable, one flavor booster and one binder or topping, like cheese or sauce. Oil, salt and pepper are free.

Seven dinners

1. Black bean sweet potatoes

Sweet potatoes, black beans, cheese, salsa. Microwave the potatoes 6 to 8 minutes, split and top. Here is the
full recipe
. (Four ingredients plus an optional topping.)

2. Pesto chicken pasta

Pasta, pesto, cherry tomatoes, parmesan and shredded rotisserie chicken. Boil the pasta, stir in pesto with a splash of pasta water, then fold in the rest.

3. Egg fried rice

Cooked rice, eggs, frozen peas and carrots, soy sauce, oil. Cold rice works best. See the
full recipe
.

4. Sheet-pan sausage and veggies

Fully cooked sausage, baby potatoes, broccoli, oil, garlic powder. Roast at 425 F. More in
easy sheet-pan dinners
.

5. Salsa chicken

Chicken breasts, salsa, taco seasoning, black beans, tortillas. Slow cook on low 6 to 7

hours until the chicken hits 165 F. See
slow cooker dinners
.

6. Tomato white bean pasta

Pasta, marinara, white beans, spinach, parmesan. One pot and about 20 minutes.

7. Cheesy quesadillas

Tortillas, cheese, black beans, salsa and any leftover chicken or vegetables. Cook in a skillet 2 to 3 minutes per side.

Swap guide

Protein swaps:
beans, eggs, tofu, sausage, canned tuna or shredded chicken.

Vegetable swaps:
use whatever is frozen or on sale.

Flavor swaps:
salsa, pesto, soy sauce, marinara or taco seasoning.

The five-ingredient weekly challenge

Pick five pantry or freezer ingredients you already own, like rice, beans, eggs, frozen vegetables and cheese. Build three different dinners from only those, plus oil, salt and pepper. Bonus points for no extra shopping trip. Use our
pantry staples list
to choose your five.

Why short ingredient lists help

They make
cost per serving
easy to calculate and are perfect for
nights with no energy
. The
5:47 p.m. Rescue Kit
can pull these together into a week plan and auto-build the list.

Let us take dinner off your plate

The Rescue Kit picks dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows what each dinner costs.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Questions, answered

Do salt, pepper and oil count as ingredients?

Most five-ingredient recipes treat them as free pantry basics, so they are not counted.

Can five-ingredient dinners be healthy?

Yes. Combining a protein, a vegetable and a whole-food starch gives you a balanced plate with very few ingredients.

Helpful outside resource

For more ways to build balanced meals while keeping food costs in view, see MyPlate's guide to healthy eating on a budget
.

Explore every dinner guide

Keep building your weeknight plan with these related guides. Each one covers a different part of getting dinner on the table.

Cheap Family Dinners With the Cost Per Serving

Learn to estimate cost per serving and stretch a grocery budget.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort ideas for exhausted nights, from quick meals to hands-off options.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One-pan dinner formulas, roasting tips and easy combinations.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Make-ahead dinner ideas, freezing tips and safe thawing guidance.

Leftover Chicken Recipes

Turn leftover chicken into several easy dinners.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

Build a practical pantry for affordable meals and less food waste.

Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas That the Whole Table Will Eat

Low-pressure family dinner ideas and practical picky-eater strategies.

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Hands-off slow cooker meals, timing tips and safe food handling.

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

A seven-night dinner plan, shopping list and ways to adjust for busy evenings.